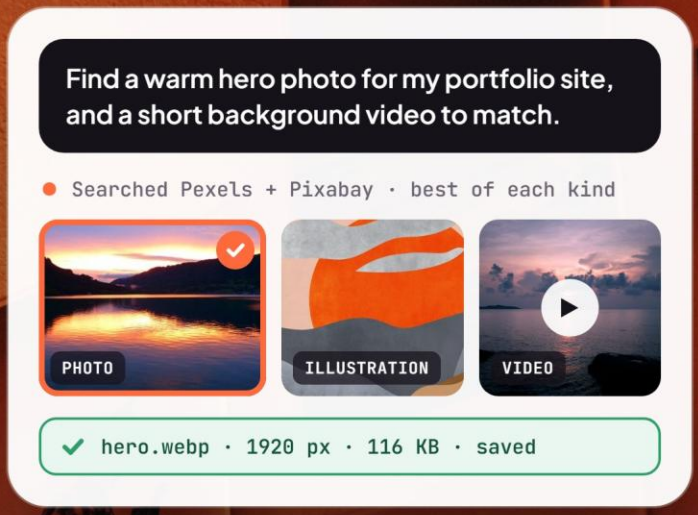
stockmedia

PLAYBOOK



THE STOCK-MEDIA PLAYBOOK

Ask for the picture. Get the right one.

How to put free photos, illustrations and video into your websites, decks and documents, one play at a time.

01 PROBLEM | 02 SOLUTION | 03 RESULT

github.com/dtsoden/stock-media-skill

A BRAND OF David Soden

START HERE

The playbook at a glance

Almost everything you make needs a picture: a website, a slide deck, a report cover, a blog post. This playbook shows how to get the right one in a couple of minutes with stock-media, a free skill you add to your AI assistant, and how to pair it with the other skills you already use.

It runs in order: the problem, then what stock-media does about it, then what good looks like. Ten plays follow, each with a clear finish line.

01
Problem
Finding a good image takes longer than making the page. Paid libraries cost money and free ones take hunting. Even then, the file you grab is rarely the right size.

02
Solution
stock-media searches Pexels and Pixabay at once, then saves the best fit as a web-ready file in your project.

03
Result
Real photos, illustrations and video in your sites, decks and documents, in minutes, with a clean license and files that load fast.

How to use it

- Read the problem, solution and result once. They take about five minutes.
- Do Play 1 first. It takes about ten minutes, and you only do it once per computer.
- Then jump to the play that matches what you're making today. Each one stands on its own.
- Every play has prompts in dark boxes. Copy them word for word, then change the subject to yours.

Get it



To install it, paste this sentence into your AI assistant. It walks you through the rest, and Play 1 has the details.

SAY THIS

```
Set up the stock-media skill by following
https://raw.githubusercontent.com/dtsoden/stock-media-skill/main/SETUP.md
```

01 THE PROBLEM

Every page needs a picture. Finding one eats the afternoon.



A website without photos looks unfinished. Decks made of bullet points lose the room, and a report with a plain title page looks like a draft. So you go looking for an image, and the hour you meant to spend on the work goes to the search instead.

The trouble is rarely that good images don't exist. Pexels and Pixabay hold millions of them, free. The trouble is everything between wanting a picture and having the right file in the right place.

What usually goes wrong

- You search one library, settle for the third-best result, and never check the other.
- An image looks fine as a thumbnail and goes soft once it's stretched across a full-width banner.
- A 6 MB photo goes straight onto a web page and slows it down for every visitor.
- A background video ships at 40 MB with its soundtrack still attached.
- Each slide gets an image from a different search, so the deck looks like a scrapbook.
- Nobody can say later where an image came from or whether its license allowed the use.
- A paid subscription renews every month for the handful of images you actually use.

Who feels it

Developers building sites who don't want to stop and become photo editors. Consultants, analysts and trainers who live in PowerPoint and Word. Small business owners who run their own website. Marketers feeding a content calendar that always wants one more image.

02 THE SOLUTION

One request searches two free libraries and hands back a file ready to use.



stock-media is a free, open-source skill for your AI assistant. You describe what you need in plain words. It searches Pexels and Pixabay together, compares what comes back, picks what fits the job, and saves a file sized and compressed for where it's going.

It works in Claude Code, Codex, Gemini CLI, Cursor, GitHub Copilot and any other tool that reads Agent Skills, the open format for adding skills to AI assistants. Your assistant decides when to use it, so most of the time you just ask for a picture.

What it does

Two libraries, one search	Every photo and video request goes to Pexels and Pixabay at once, so you choose from both pools instead of settling for one.
Photos, illustrations and video	Pixabay adds illustrations, vector art and animations. Video comes from both libraries, up to 4K footage on Pexels.
Picks for the job	It matches orientation, size and color to where the image is going and looks at the previews before it chooses. Pixabay results flagged as AI-generated or low quality never make the shortlist.
Web-ready files	Images come back as WebP at the width you need. Video is trimmed, compressed to MP4 with the sound removed, and paired with a poster image.
Honest about limits	Pixabay's free images stop at 1280 pixels wide. The skill keeps those out of full-width spots and tells you when a limit shaped its pick.
Keys stay out of the chat	Setup stores your two free API keys in your computer's vault or settings, never in the conversation or your project.

03 THE RESULT

Real pictures in everything you make, in minutes.



What you end up with

- Websites with real photography instead of grey boxes.
- Decks where every slide shares the same light and color, because one search fed them all.
- Documents and reports with a cover worth opening. This playbook's cover is one.
- Pages that stay fast, because every image is sized and compressed for where it sits.
- A record of where each image came from, so the license question has an answer.
- No subscription bill for images you use a few times a month.

How you'll know it's working

MEASURE	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Time to first image	A couple of minutes between asking and having the file in your project.
File size	Hero images in the low hundreds of kilobytes, not megabytes. The 1920-pixel hero on this playbook's cover card came out at 116 KB.
Sharpness	Nothing looks soft at its display size. Full-width images come from sources at least that wide.
Consistency	Every image in a page or deck shares a tone, a light and a palette.
Traceability	You can name the library and the photographer for every image you used.

> No skill can make an average photo great. stock-media finds the best of what two free libraries offer and prepares it properly. When nothing fits, it says so. That's your cue to commission a shoot or try a paid library.

04 THE PLAYS

Ten plays, in the order you'll need them



Each play has a goal, what it's good for, what it pairs with, a few steps and a finish line. The prompts in the dark boxes are written to be copied word for word. Change the subject and keep the shape.

PLAY 1

Get set up

Goal: the skill installed and your two free keys stored safely.

1. Open your AI assistant in any project folder and paste this:

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Set up the stock-media skill by following
   https://raw.githubusercontent.com/dtsoden/stock-media-skill/main/SETUP.md
   ```

2. Follow along as it checks for Python and installs what's missing. Say yes to video if you want background videos.
3. Create your two free keys when it asks: one at pexels.com/api and one at pixabay.com/api/docs.
4. Pick where to keep them. For most people, the computer's own credential store is the right answer.
5. When it opens a text file, paste each key after its = sign, save, close the file, and tell the assistant you're done. It tests both keys, stores them and deletes the file.
6. Start a new session so your assistant picks up the skill.

> YOU'RE DONE WHEN
> the assistant reports both keys as OK and the skill shows up in a new session.

PLAY 2

Build a website with real pictures

Goal: every image slot on the site filled with a real photo, sized for where it sits.

Use it for: a new site or landing page, or replacing placeholder boxes in an existing one.

Pairs with: a frontend design skill such as Anthropic's frontend-design or web-artifacts-builder, or the framework you already use.

1. Build or open the page first, so the assistant can see the layout, the colors and where each image goes.
2. Ask for every image in one request, so they come from one search and match.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Fill every image slot on this landing page with real photos from stock-media. Warm natural light, people at work, no posed handshakes. Match the site's colors.
   ```
3. Let it place the files in your images folder and update the code. Hero images come back at 1920 pixels, cards at 800.
4. Check the page on a phone and on a wide screen. If a crop cuts off a face, ask for a different pick.
5. Ask for alt text while you're there.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Write alt text for every image you just added, describing what's in each one.
   ```

YOU'RE DONE WHEN
no placeholder images remain, and the images on the page add up to a few hundred kilobytes rather than several megabytes.

PLAY 3

Put a video behind the headline

Goal: a muted background loop that sets the mood without slowing the page.

Use it for: hero sections, event pages and product launches.

Pairs with: the same web design skills as Play 2.

1. Describe the motion and the mood. Calm, slow clips loop best.

SAY THIS
```
Find a calm 10-second background video of morning light through trees for the hero section. Landscape, no text in the shot, compressed for the web with a poster image.
```

2. The skill trims the clip, removes the sound, compresses it to MP4 and saves a poster frame that shows while the video loads.
3. Check that the video tag has autoplay, muted, loop and playsinline. Browsers block autoplay when there is sound.
4. Make sure the headline still reads over the moving picture. Ask for a darker overlay if it doesn't.
5. Ask it to pause the video for visitors who've turned on reduced motion.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN
the video plays on desktop and phone, the file is a few megabytes at most, and the headline reads clearly over it.

PLAY 4

Make a deck that looks designed

Goal: slides with full-bleed images that share one look.

Use it for: pitches, keynotes, training sessions and quarterly reviews.

Pairs with: the pptx skill in Claude, Copilot in PowerPoint, or any skill that writes slides. Google Slides opens the finished file.

1. Write the outline first, one line per slide. Then decide which slides get an image. Usually that means the title, the section dividers and any slide that tells a story.
2. Ask for the images as a set, with one visual direction.

SAY THIS
```
For this 12-slide outline, find one image for the title slide and one for each of the four section dividers. Same mood throughout: cool blue light, open space on the left for text. Landscape, at least 1920 pixels wide.
```

3. Have the slide skill build the deck with those images full-bleed and the text in the open space.
4. For diagrams and concept slides, ask for illustrations instead of photos. They explain an idea better than people at desks.
5. Flip through in presentation mode and swap any image that pulls attention from its words.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN
every image slide shares the same tone and no text sits on a busy part of a photo.

PLAY 5

Give a document a cover

Goal: a report, proposal or playbook with a cover that makes people open it.

Use it for: white papers, client proposals, analyst reports, playbooks and course workbooks.

Pairs with: the docx and pdf skills, canvas-design, or any report skill you use.

1. Decide the feeling first. One clear subject with room for a title beats a busy scene.
2. Ask for portrait images with space for text.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Find a portrait cover photo for a playbook about stock images. Warm light, photographs
   on a wall, room at the bottom for a large title. At least 2500 pixels tall.
   ```
3. Look at the shortlist and pick one. Have the design skill lay the title, subtitle and logo over it, with a dark gradient so the type reads.
4. Ask for two or three wide band images in the same palette to open each section.
5. Put credits on the back page. Both licenses make them optional, but they show where everything came from.

This playbook did exactly this. The cover photo, the three thumbnails in its floating card and every section band came from stock-media searches, and the card shows real numbers: the skill saved that hero image at 1920 pixels and 116 KB. The back page lists every photographer.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN
the cover still reads at thumbnail size, the way people first see it in an inbox or a file list.

PLAY 6

Illustrate the product

Goal: friendly illustrations where a photo would feel wrong.

Use it for: empty states, onboarding screens, 404 pages, error messages, help articles and email headers.

Pairs with: frontend design skills and your app's own components.

1. Ask for illustrations rather than photos. Only Pixabay has them, so the skill searches there.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Find a flat illustration for the empty inbox screen. Calm and friendly, two or three colors that match our brand, transparent background if possible.
   ```

2. Vector art comes back as a 1280-pixel image, often with a transparent background, saved as WebP. That covers most screens.
3. If you need a true scalable SVG, the skill gives you the Pixabay page so you can download it by hand.
4. Keep one illustration style across the product. When you find an artist you like, ask for more of their work.

> YOU'RE DONE WHEN
> every empty or error screen has an image, and they all look like they belong together.

PLAY 7

Feed the content calendar

Goal: a featured image for every post, in every size it needs.

Use it for: blog posts, newsletters, LinkedIn and other social posts, and event announcements.

Pairs with: content and marketing skills, and your blog or email platform.

1. Write the post first. The image should follow the point.
2. Ask for the image and its sizes in one go.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Find a featured image for this post about remote team rituals. Save a 1200 by 630 crop for the blog and social cards, and a 1080 square for Instagram.
   ```

3. For newsletters, upload the file to your email platform. Pixabay's download links expire after about a day, so never link to them directly.
4. Avoid recognizable people in anything that suggests they endorse you. Both licenses forbid it.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN
each post has its image in every size it needs, stored in your own media library.

PLAY 8

Prototype with real content

Goal: mockups and demos that look like the finished thing.

Use it for: client pitches, design reviews, product demos and sales demos.

Pairs with: design and prototyping skills, and app builders.

1. Swap every grey box for a real image before the review. People react to the real thing, not to a wireframe.
2. Ask for images that match the client's world.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   Fill this restaurant app prototype with real food photos: overhead shots, natural light, 800 pixels wide for the menu cards.
   ```
3. Use a video in the hero if the final product will have one, so nobody is surprised later.
4. Keep the shortlist. If the client likes the direction, the final build can use the same images.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN
people stop commenting on the placeholders and start commenting on the product.

PLAY 9

Refresh a whole site

Goal: every image on a site replaced or re-optimized in one pass, with one consistent look.

Use it for: a rebrand, a redesign, or a site that has grown a patchwork of images over the years.

Pairs with: siteseoai, the free SEO skill from the same author, which checks page speed and missing alt text.

1. Ask for an inventory first.

   SAY THIS
   ```
   List every image on this site with its size in kilobytes, its dimensions and where it's used. Flag anything over 300 KB or wider than it's shown.
   ```

2. Write down one visual direction for the new look: light, palette, subject and mood.
3. Replace images section by section, using the same direction in every request.
4. Re-optimize the images you keep to WebP at their display size.
5. Run siteseoai afterward to confirm the pages got faster and no image lost its alt text.

> YOU'RE DONE WHEN
> the site looks like one project and its total image weight has dropped.

PLAY 10

Make it a habit

Goal: good images become the default rather than a special effort.

1. Add a line to your project's instructions file (CLAUDE.md, AGENTS.md or your tool's equivalent) telling the assistant to use stock-media for any image or video the project needs.
2. Keep a short visual direction note in the project, so every request starts from the same look.
3. Follow the rhythm below.

> YOU'RE DONE WHEN
> the assistant reaches for the skill without being asked.

WHEN	DO THIS
Starting a project	Write the visual direction note and add the stock-media line to the project instructions.
Building a page or deck	Ask for images as a set, in one request, with the direction note.
Before publishing	Check sharpness and file size at the real display size, and add alt text.
Every quarter	Run the Play 9 inventory on live sites and replace anything stale.
When a key stops working	Make a new key on the provider's site and run setup again.

BETTER TOGETHER

Skills that pair with stock-media

stock-media finds and prepares the media. Other skills decide where it goes. These are the pairings that come up most.

PAIR IT WITH	WHAT THAT SKILL MAKES	WHAT STOCK-MEDIA ADDS
frontend-design or web-artifacts-builder	Web pages and app screens	Real photos, illustrations and background video, sized for each slot
pptx, or Copilot in PowerPoint	Slide decks	Full-bleed title and section images that share one look
docx and pdf	Reports, proposals, playbooks	Covers and section bands, like the ones in this playbook
canvas-design and theme-factory	Posters, one-pagers, themed visuals	Photographic backgrounds and textures to design over
Content and marketing skills	Blog posts, newsletters, social posts	A featured image in every size each channel needs
siteseoai	SEO and AI search checks	Lighter pages and images with alt text, which siteseoai then confirms
Your own skills in Codex, Gemini CLI, Cursor or GitHub Copilot	Whatever your team builds	The same media search, because they all read Agent Skills

The skills marked as Anthropic's (frontend-design, web-artifacts-builder, pptx, docx, pdf, canvas-design and theme-factory) are published in Anthropic's public skills collection, and most AI tools that read Agent Skills can install them.

Microsoft is bringing Agent Skills into Microsoft 365 Copilot, starting with agents built in Agent Builder and Copilot Studio, which are in preview as of October 2026. GitHub Copilot and Visual Studio already read them. As each Copilot surface opens up, stock-media works there the same way.

WHAT'S POSSIBLE

Ideas by who you are

The plays cover the common jobs. Here's what else people make once finding an image stops being a chore.

A developer	Seed a demo database with real product photos. Give every empty state an illustration. Put a background video on the docs site.
A consultant or analyst	Put a photographic cover on every client deliverable. Open each section of a long report with a band image. Give each chapter of a dense deck its own visual.
A trainer or teacher	Illustrate workbooks and quizzes. Run short video loops behind title slides. Build a picture glossary for new terms.
A marketer	Keep a featured image ready for every post. Build a mood board from real search results before a photo shoot. Cut one image to every size each channel needs.
A small business owner	Replace the template photos on your website. Make a seasonal banner. Give your price list or menu a proper header.
A product team	Fill prototypes with real content. Make onboarding screens friendly. Prepare launch visuals before the real photography is ready.

What the licenses rule out

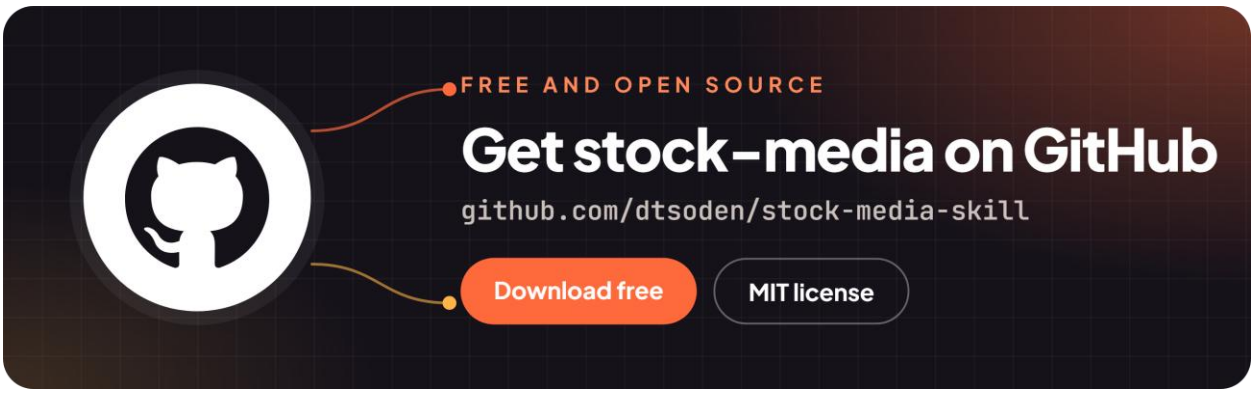
Some uses are off limits under both the Pexels and the Pixabay license, and the skill doesn't change that. Check the full terms for anything unusual.

- Selling an image or video on its own, unaltered, or putting it on another stock or wallpaper site.
- Using an image as part of a logo, trademark, business name or service mark.
- Suggesting that people or brands in an image endorse your product.
- Showing identifiable people in a bad light, or using any image in a misleading or illegal way.

05 FREE AND OPEN SOURCE

Free to use. Open to read. Yours to keep.

stock-media costs nothing. The code is public on GitHub under the MIT license, so you can read every step it takes and change it to suit you. If the project ever stops, your copy keeps working.



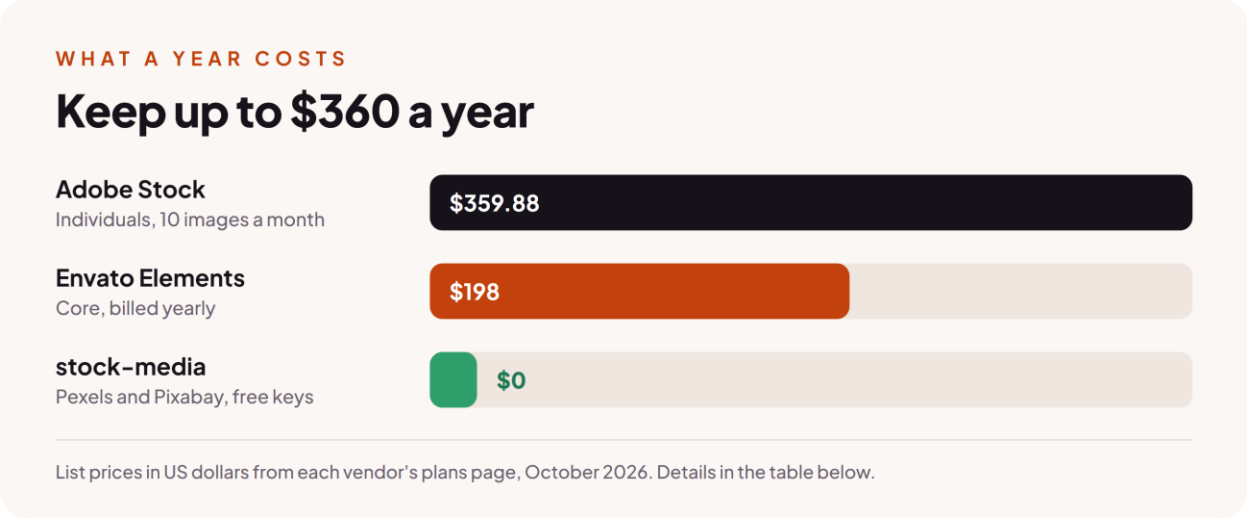
Download it or read the code: github.com/dtsoden/stock-media-skill

- No subscription and no per-image fees. Pexels and Pixabay are free, and so are their API keys.
- Your images live in your project, not on someone else's server.
- Your keys stay in your computer's vault, never in a chat log.
- It works in whichever AI assistant you use, today and after you switch.

WHAT YOU'D PAY ELSEWHERE

The money you keep

If you pay for a stock subscription mainly to get a handful of images a month, here's what two popular plans cost at list price.



LIBRARY	WHAT YOU GET	LIST PRICE	A YEAR
Adobe Stock, Individuals	Up to 10 images or 1 video a month	$29.99 a month	$359.88
Envato Elements, Core	Subscription library, billed yearly	$16.50 a month	$198
stock-media with Pexels and Pixabay	Free photos, illustrations and video, within the API rate limits	Free	$0

Prices are each vendor's published list prices in US dollars on their plans pages in October 2026. Vendors change prices, so check before you buy or cancel.

> Be fair about the trade. Paid libraries have bigger catalogs, editorial and exclusive images, and some plans include legal protection if a license is ever challenged. Pexels and Pixabay offer none of that. If your work needs those things, keep the paid plan and use stock-media for everything else.

06 GROUND RULES

What stock-media won't do

It's built to be trusted with your keys and your projects. These rules hold every time it runs.

Put your keys in the chat	Setup stores them with a script and a text file it deletes afterward. It never prints a key, and if you paste one by mistake it tells you to replace it.
Link to images it doesn't hold	Every file is downloaded into your project. Pixabay's links expire, and hotlinked images break pages.
Pass off a soft image	It won't put a 1280-pixel Pixabay image in a full-width slot, and it tells you when a limit shaped its choice.
Pick what it hasn't looked at	It views the previews of shortlisted images before choosing, rather than trusting tags alone.
Play sound you didn't ask for	Background videos come back muted with a poster frame, and pause for visitors who prefer reduced motion.

07 QUICK REFERENCE

Prompts you'll use

Plain requests work. These are the ones that come up most.

SAY THIS	WHAT YOU GET
Set up the stock-media skill by following its SETUP.md	Install and key setup (Play 1)
Find a hero photo for this page	One 1920-pixel WebP, saved and wired into the code
Fill every image slot on this page	A matching set of photos for the whole layout
Find a 10-second background video of …	A trimmed, muted MP4 plus a poster image
Find an illustration for the empty state	A Pixabay illustration as WebP, transparent where possible
Find a portrait cover photo with room for a title	A shortlist of tall images with space for type
Only use Pexels for this one	A single-library search, for when you need full resolution
Credit every image you added	A credits list with photographer and source link
List every image on this site with its size	The inventory for Play 9

Tools that list skills as commands also take `/stock-media` followed by your request.

stockmedia

Ask for the picture. Get the right one.

Free and open source. github.com/dtsoden/stock-media-skill

STOCK-MEDIA IS A BRAND OF

David Soden

davidsoden.com

EVERY IMAGE IN THIS PLAYBOOK WAS FOUND WITH STOCK-MEDIA

Cover: GURYAN on Pexels
Photo thumbnail: Pixabay on Pexels
Illustration thumbnail: BiancaVanDijk on Pixabay
Video thumbnail: magicmore on Pixabay
Problem band: Nguyen Huy on Pexels
Solution band: Pavel Danilyuk on Pexels
Result band: David Waschbüsch on Pexels
Plays band: Lucas Andrade on Pexels